Week 3: Web Scraping

This week's workshop on web scraping changed my understanding of how websites can be approached as research objects. Before the workshop, I mainly understood scraping as a technical process of extracting visible text or posts from webpages. However, working with HTML structures and selectors helped me recognise that websites are not simply collections of textual information, but structured digital environments in which information is organised and presented through code. Their headings, links, lists and visual hierarchies shape how information becomes accessible and visible. This made me realise that an interface can be understood as more than a container for content; it also reflects decisions about how information is organised and prioritised.

Venturini and Rogers (2025) provide a useful framework for understanding this relationship between documents, interfaces and digital methods. Their discussion of scraping documents and interfaces encouraged me to consider how the technical structure of a webpage can become a source of research data. However, the practical process also made me aware that web scraping is not a neutral form of data collection. When using selectors to identify particular HTML elements, researchers must decide which information to include and which to exclude. For example, focusing on headings and paragraphs may overlook hyperlinks, images or other interactive elements. Therefore, the resulting dataset does not necessarily represent the webpage in its entirety, but rather a particular selection of information shaped by the researcher's methodological decisions. This raises an important question about how the construction of a dataset can influence what researchers subsequently observe and interpret. Furthermore, changes in webpage structures or dynamically loaded content may create additional difficulties, meaning that the accessibility and completeness of scraped data cannot always be assumed.

The workshop also encouraged me to consider the ethical responsibilities involved in collecting digital data. As Tiidenberg (2018) discusses, digital research requires researchers to consider the expectations, privacy and rights of those whose online activities or content become research material. Public accessibility does not automatically make all forms of data collection ethically acceptable. Researchers therefore need to consider not only whether information can technically be collected, but also whether collecting, storing and presenting it is appropriate. This is particularly relevant when webpages contain personal information or content created for a specific audience.

Finally, building my own portfolio website gave this methodological discussion a more personal dimension. When designing my pixel-art portfolio, I made deliberate decisions about which projects to highlight, how to organise information and which elements should attract visitors' attention. If my website were scraped and analysed, the resulting data would reflect both my original design decisions and the researcher's choices about what to extract. This made me more aware that digital data is shaped by

multiple layers of selection and interpretation. Overall, I now understand web scraping not simply as a technical tool for collecting online information, but as a research method that requires critical decisions about data construction, interpretation and ethics.

Below are the outputs from my web scrape.

file:///Users/chuuya/Desktop/bbcprogs.csv